

Baker Street Irregular

Sherlock Holmes in a flawed avatar in a twist of Conan Doyle's classics



THE CURIOUS CASE OF 221B
by PARTHA BASU
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 299
Pages: 277

| By Dilip Bobb |

There's this curious case of the bookstore owner in suburban Gurgaon. All day, he's surrounded by books and the ghosts of writers past. When footfalls are light, he rereads classics, in particular, his favourite, Arthur Conan Doyle's tales involving the world's most famous fictional detective, Sherlock Holmes. Partha Basu, the bookstore owner, has

something in common with the pipe-smoking sleuth; he too is a lover of puzzles. The plot thickens when he is struck by a Holmesian idea: what if the brilliant detecting had an unflattering backstory? Would not a flawed Holmes, who stumbled on success through luck or being the fortunate victim of a con, be more interesting as fictional character, particularly if there was an Indian connection?

Elementary Dr Watson, put it in a book. The result is *The Curious Case of 221B*, which, any Holmes fan will know, is the Baker Street address of the detective which he shared with his friend and chronicler, Dr Watson. Now here's the new twist in the old tale. Post his partnership with Holmes, Watson befriends and becomes surrogate father to an Indian, known only as Kumar, and his English wife, who return to India and are murdered by hooligans.

Their son, Jit, arrives at their house to take inventory and discovers secret diaries penned by Watson. The diaries concern some famous cases involving the duo and expose the "real" story which puts Holmes in an extremely unfavourable light and also flies in the face of the 'official'

accounts in the Holmesian canon.

Fiction begets fiction. What follows in the form of Watson's secret diaries is a skilful retelling of some of their more famous cases. As Holmes's Boswell, Watson wrote the Holmes stories as frame narratives written from his viewpoint and Basu follows the same style and format in his parody of the famous detective. The book is written as three parallel narratives: Watson's diaries, Jit's story and a "mid word" from Emma, Mrs Hudson's daughter. In Basu's version, Dr Watson marries Mrs Hudson, who was housekeeper to the duo at 221B, and thus privy to many facts relating to their cases. Basu has a wonderful way with words and gets Conan Doyle's style of prose and turn-of-the-century atmosphere almost word perfect. The twist he adds to stories as in *A Scandal in Bohemia* and *The Three Students* is equally artful. In both, the so-called victims actually plant their own clues to get Holmes to do exactly what they want, ultimately using the legendary detective and his reputation to succeed in their elaborate con. Similar twists in the tale strip Holmes of his famed façade and expose him as less than brilliant.

Basu does take some unnecessary literary detours, adding a true life case involving a Parsi gentleman in the UK who was accused of a crime and was later cleared after an investigation by Conan Doyle himself. For all that, this is a wonderfully refreshing parody of a classic and by selecting from Conan Doyle's collection of short stories, he is able to inject credibility into his flights of fancy backed by intensive research. In terms of plot, period atmosphere and literary style, this can only be classified a Baker Street Irregular. ■



SAURABH SINGH



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